

« I want to be remembered as a good person,
not just a good player »

FAZEL ATRACHALI

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As Hyderabad prepared to illuminate its skyline with the festive glow of Diwali, Bengal Warriorz's captain, Fazel Atrachali, ignited a spark of his own. In a dazzling display of defensive prowess, the Iranian scripted history by becoming the first-ever player to amass 500 tackle points in the Pro Kabaddi League (PKL).

Affectionately known as 'the Sultan', he achieved this milestone during a nail-biting encounter against defending champion Puneri Paltan, which ended in a tie. His third tackle point of the match etched his name in the annals of PKL history. It took the left-corner defender ten seasons and 173 matches to conquer a summit no other had been able to climb.

"I never imagined that one day I would be the most successful defender in the PKL, let alone reaching this milestone. When I started playing kabaddi in my village, people told me I was not good enough and should pursue another sport. From that day to this, it's been 21 years," says the four-time Asian Games medallist to *Sportstar*.

In a sport that originated in ancient India, the Iranian has been one of the poster boys of its most prominent professional league for nearly a decade. However, his PKL journey hasn't been as uninterrupted

as his stats suggest.

"The first time I came to PKL, nobody believed in me. Ten years ago, I wanted one chance to play on the mat, and after a lot of hard work, many injuries, and time away from family, I had to be happy with the success. A big thank you to everybody who has helped me on this journey," says the two-time PKL winner.

Snapped up by the Kolkata-based franchise for Rs. 50 lakh, Fazel was tasked with shoring up the Bengal Warriorz's defensive line. The seasoned campaigner was also handed a bigger responsibility — the captain's armband.

Now in his fifth PKL franchise, the most successful captain in the league's history feels more at ease than ever with the Warriorz. United with old friend Maninder Singh and backed by experienced defender Nitesh Kumar, he's ready to lead his team to new heights.

"This is a dream," Fazel enthuses. "Having two such experienced players by my side allows me to play with freedom and aggression. I'm not burdened with constant tactical directives. Mani and Nitesh have that covered. I can focus on fulfilling my role on the mat."

A global vision

Despite the glamour and glitz of the PKL, Fazel is concerned about the

future of the sport outside India and Iran.

"The last Asian Games was like a village tournament; only India and Iran competed. Countries like South Korea, which used to be good, have stopped playing due to the lack of international tournaments," he says.

Fazel, who led Iran to its first-ever gold in the Asian Games when it defeated India in Jakarta-Palembang 2018, holds a pessimistic view on international tournaments.

When asked about the proposed 2025 Kabaddi World Cup, he said, "I've heard this 'next year' promise for nearly a decade now. I hear it but don't believe it."

As the sport continues to professionalise, Fazel aspires to elevate it to a global stage, including the Olympics. He believes that increasing international participation is crucial to achieving this goal. "We need more countries to compete," he says, highlighting the limited number of international tournaments since 2016.

Beyond the mat

A ferocious defender on the mat, the Iranian is a soft-spoken and friendly person off it. A role model for many young players, he's known for his tactical brilliance.

"Fazel has a unique perspective on the game. He's a fantastic tactician